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Struggle for change in a Nubian community

Author(S): Kennedy, John G., Fahim, Hussein M.

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Although weddings, funerals, yearly feasts, Ramadan, the birthday of the Prophet, and other social and ceremonial occasions interrupt the regular routine of the village, segregation by sex is consistently maintained. At weddings, the women dance together opposite the men, eat separately, and play separate complementary roles throughout the celebration. At funerals, they sit together in the house ritually weeping and wailing while the men sit outside preparing the shroud. The body is washed by a member of the same sex as the deceased. The men carry the casket to the cemetery in an exclusively male procession, eating at the mosque for three days after the interment; women meanwhile gather to eat with the female relatives at the house of the deceased.

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Ramadan is the only time of the year when women are permitted to enter the mosque for the nightly service; again, however, they stay at the rear, separated from the men by a large curtain. After the service, men go to the village club for an evening of jokes, stories, and speeches while women visit one another's houses in small groups. During the entertainment programs occasionally put on by the club, men sit on benches at one side of the courtyard while women and girls sit across from them on the ground. The skits enacted at these programs have all-male casts notwithstanding that female roles are frequently involved.

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The yearly feasts are the only occasions when every man encounters every woman of the village. At these celebrations, the men make a procession to all the houses in the community, where the women of each household greet them and serve them cookies, candy, and cinnamon tea. This annual ritual seems to represent a symbolic rapprochement between the sexes, emphasizing their physical separation and dramatizing their complementary roles. After the procession, however, the customary communal meal takes place in sexually segregated neighborhood groups.

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Effects of sexual separation There is no question that segregation by sex impedes the flow of information in the community. Of a 40 percent random sample of the married women in the village, not one gave information that tallied exactly with that of her husband in regard to his income: 48 percent gave a figure different from that given by the husband, while 52 percent had no idea what his income was. Several women were uncertain of their husband's occupation; one did not know where her husband worked; there were also several cases in which women had no idea how much land their fathers owned.

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Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



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